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SERIAL NO. 0031
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STATE-WAR-NAVY COORDINATING COMMITTEE
SUBCOMMITTEE FOR THE FAR EAST
Munitions Building
Washington, D.C.

3 August 1945

Memorandum for Mr. H. M. Benninghoff:
Captain Lorenzo Sabin:

Subject: SFE 104 - National Composition of Forces to Occupy Formosa

1. As written this paper is not acceptable to me, for the following reasons:

a. Paragraph 7 reads: "The United States should occupy and establish military government in Formosa unless circumstances make it possible for China to undertake this responsibility." In my opinion, which is based on known War Department policy and also on the policy as expressed in SWNCC 87/2 (paragraph 5 of the Discussion and paragraph 12d of the Conclusion, attached for your convenience), the statement should be revised to read, "China should occupy and establish the military government of Formosa unless circumstances make it impossible for her to undertake this responsibility." I can see no good reason why the U.S. should set up, at considerable cost, the military government for a territory which is to become Chinese. It is implicit in the paper that there is no confidence in the "ability of the Chinese to exercise such responsibilities." (paragraph 10, page 2). What this boils down to, is that the Chinese probably will not govern Formosa as efficiently as we would, nor in the same way. If followed to the logical conclusion, this attitude would have us in Formosa for the next 4000-odd years - which is manifest absurdity.

b. If it becomes necessary for us to assault Formosa in order to reduce it, then there is no question but that we should establish the initial military government. In such case, our forces would simply spearhead Chinese assault and presumably would be withdrawn at a very early stage. At the time of the withdrawal military government should be turned over to the Chinese.

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74-0132
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SECRET

g. If, however, it is a matter of merely accepting the surrender of the Japanese on Formosa then the occupying forces should be Chinese, even though the United States would have to provide certain shipping and troops to run the port facilities. I can see no necessity whatever for the United States to assume the burden of an interim government between the time the Japanese flag is hauled down and the Chinese flag hoisted.

2. I recommend that the paper be recommitted by informal agreement of the SFE members and that the Working Party produce a paper in line with the provisions of 87/2 and of the foregoing discussion. Will you please inform the Secretary, Lt. Farley, of your concurrence or informally give him your comments.

F. N. ROBERTS
Brig. Gen., USA
Army Member

per Hugh D. Farley

Enclosure

cc: Lt. Col. Fahey
cc: Lt. Farley

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790132
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SECRET

SWNCC 87/1/D
23 May 1945

DISCUSSION:

5. "The problem of the establishment and continuance of the military government in Formosa is closely related to future military operations. The Department of State has recommended that 'If the Armed Forces of the United States undertake and effect the occupation and liberation of Formosa, the military administration for civil affairs in Formosa will be established by the United States' It is envisaged that such civil affairs administration will continue until such time as Chinese sovereignty is restored".

CONCLUSIONS:

11. d. "If Formosa is occupied by American forces in the course of operations military government should be established and continued until Formosa is transferred to Chinese sovereignty or until an appropriate time when such military government could be turned over to China".

SWNCC 87/2

DISCUSSION:

5. "The problem of the establishment and continuance of the military government in Formosa is closely related to future military operations. If the armed forces of the United States undertake and effect the occupation and liberation of Formosa, the military administration for civil affairs in Formosa should be established by the United States. However, if the military government has not been established in Formosa as an incident to military operations by the time of Japan's unconditional surrender or total defeat, it is not considered advisable or necessary that Formosa be occupied by United States forces, or that military government be established by such forces for the purpose of enforcing decisions relating to the post-defeat treatment of Japan. It is envisaged that in this contingency that Formosa will be occupied and administered by Chinese forces".

CONCLUSIONS:

12. d. "If Formosa is occupied by American forces in the course of operations the military government which will have been established should be continued into the post-defeat period until an appropriate time when such military government could be turned over to China. If military government has not been established as an incident to combat operations, United States forces should not be established in Formosa during the post-defeat period for the purpose of enforcing decisions relating to the post-defeat treatment of Japan".

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